

PROCESS

The project began with a practical question: after wearing a separate back protector for a winter of skiing, I wondered why protection could not be integrated directly into the ski jacket. Fit and comfort issues led me to explore how back, hip, tailbone and knee protection could become part of the garment itself. I initially developed two directions: a utilitarian outfit focused on technical performance, and a more expressive outfit responding to the increasingly fashion-driven culture of the slopes. Through sketching, pattern development, prototyping and conversations with technical pattern makers, I explored how protection, mobility, comfort and aesthetics could coexist.

During this process, I established a collaboration with Spines, a Dutch back-protector company, which provided financial support, resources and technical insight. However, further research made me question the fundamental assumption behind my work: even if I designed a safer jacket, would people actually want to wear it? Protection is not only a technical issue; it carries social associations with inexperience, caution and incompetence.

The focus therefore shifted from hiding protection to making it desirable and visible. The final outfit acts as a proof of concept for this idea. A neon green colour increases visibility on the slopes, while laser-cut openings reveal the integrated protection through vintage lace patterns. The lace references how materials and aesthetics can change meaning over time, while the specific pattern remains interchangeable.

The final outcome combines the functional prototype with a fictional campaign of posters and flyers, using fashion, humour and visual communication to challenge the social perception of protection and encourage its adoption.